

Finding a Reputable and Skilled Preparer

Start by asking friends, family, coworkers, and other professionals for recommendations. If you can't come up with a recommendation this way, try contacting the local chapter of a professional association such as the American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (AICPA). Once you've identified someone you'd like to use, talk to her on the phone and ask about her qualifications, background, and fees. Find out whether she works full- or part-time doing tax consulting, how many years of experience she has, and whether she participates in continuing professional education. The latter is important because tax preparers need to keep up with yearly changes in tax laws. When you've made a decision, make an appointment well in advance of the filing deadline.